THE GLOBAL DOCTRINE

IS CUBA GOING TO BE THE NEXT VENEZUELLA?

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20th March
2026

"MAYBE WE'LL HAVE A FRIENDLY TAKEOVER OF CUBA."

-TRUMP TO REUTERS

WHY TRUMP SAYS CUBA NEXT?

On 10 march 2026, ***Donald J. Trump*** said as he left the White House for a trip to Texas. "They have no money. They have no anything right now, but they're talking with us, and maybe we'll have a friendly takeover of Cuba." -Reuters

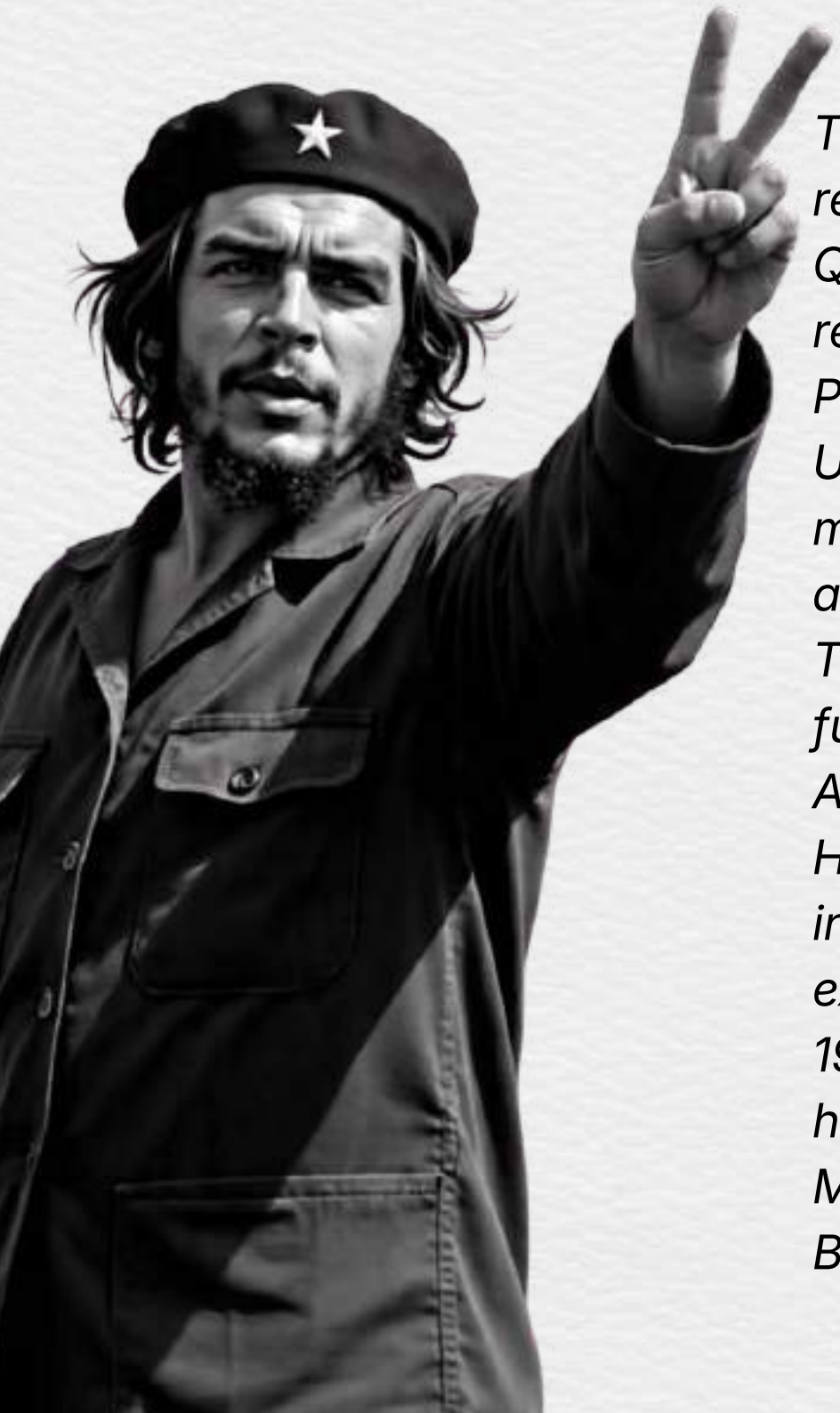
This writing piece will discuss the current crisis in Cuba, the history of the US-Cuba relations and the strategic calculations of the United States they are using to re-engage with Cuba, with President Diaz-Canel's resignation and United States-backed political re-structuring of the island nation as the most likely outcome.

Cuba is on the verge of a collapse of its government due to a cumulative crisis of fuel supplies. This fuel crisis has triggered the country's electricity supply, water supply, healthcare system and indirectly affected the tourism industry. The crisis has been fueled by decades of sanctions imposed by the United States along with the collapse of Cuba's principal ally Venezuela and the termination of oil supplies by Mexico due to oil embargo and threats by the USA. In this context, the Trump Administration has intensified the pressure on Cuba as they are portraying the island nation as a threat to national security.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

1.RELATIONS RIGHT AFTER CUBAN INDEPENDENCE:

After Spain was defeated in the third and final Cuban independence war in 1898, the USA occupied Cuba and imposed the Platt Amendment in 1901, which legitimized the military invasion of 1898. Cuba officially gained independence on June 20, 1902. But US influence persisted through the Guantánamo Bay lease and repeated military interventions.



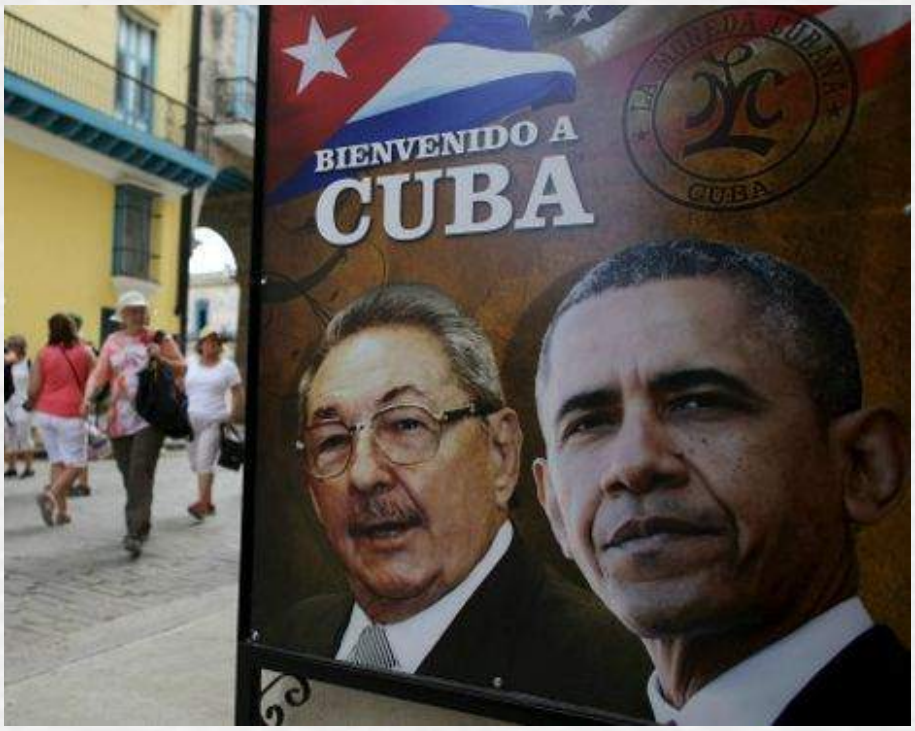
The 1903 Reciprocal Commercial Convention regulated bilateral trade, while the Hay-Quesada Treaty (signed 1904, ratified 1925) recognized Cuban ownership of the Isle of Pines. Cuba also leased Guantánamo to the United States as a naval station. The US military intervened multiple times, in 1906 and again in 1917, in an aim to suppress instability. The US Legation in Havana was elevated to full Embassy status in 1923, and Pan American Airways inaugurated the first Key West–Havana flight in 1927. Political turmoil intensified under Machado's authoritarian extension of power and Batista's coups of 1933 and 1952. By the mid-1950s, Fidel Castro had launched a guerrilla war from the Sierra Maestra mountains, directly challenging Batista's increasingly illegitimate regime.

2.AFTER THE FALL OF FULGENCIO BATISTA AND COMMUNIST TAKEOVER OF CUBA:

Fulgencio Batista, who was backed by Washington for his anticommunist stance, was overthrown by Fidel Castro's 26th of July Movement in 1959. After taking power, Castro nationalized all foreign assets and aligned with the Soviet Union. The Kennedy administration imposed a full trade embargo by 1962, which ultimately cost Cuba an estimated $130 billion. A CIA-sponsored brigade of 1,400 Cuban exiles failed to overthrow Castro at the Bay of Pigs in 1961. The following year, US spy aircraft discovered Soviet nuclear missile installations in Cuba, which triggered the Cuban Missile Crisis. It was a thirteen-day standoff resolved through secret back-channel negotiations that led to the Washington-Moscow Hotline and the Nuclear Test Ban Treaty.

Relations remained at a standstill throughout the Cold War. Reagan designated Cuba a state sponsor of terrorism in 1982. The 1994 balsero crisis prompted the "wet foot, dry foot" policy, and the 1996 Helms-Burton Act codified the embargo, penalizing foreign firms doing business with Cuba and conditioning sanctions relief on democratic reforms.

3.POLICY CHANGE DURING THE DIFFRENT US ADMINISTRATION:



Obama restored full diplomatic ties in 2014 through a prisoner swap involving the Cuban Five and aid worker Alan Gross, which was brokered partly by Pope Francis, with both nations reopening embassies in 2015. Trump reversed these gains in 2017, banning dealings with GAESA, the Cuban military's commercial corporation, and returned Cuba to the terrorism list in 2021.

Biden partially reversed course, restoring the Cuban Family Reunification Parole Program and removing Cuba from the terrorism list in early 2025 through a Church-mediated prisoner release deal. Trump immediately reimposed the terrorism designation on his first day back in office, reactivated Title III of the Helms-Burton Act, and by January 2026, following the US capture of Venezuela's Nicolás Maduro, Cuba's key oil supplier, Trump declared Cuba a "failing nation," leaving relations at one of the most adversarial points in decades.

DURING A PRESS CONFERENCE PRESIDENT TRUMP STATED THAT

"We will not allow hostile foreign influence to gain a foothold in this hemisphere, including the Panama Canal, which was discussed.' He emphasized the United States' firm stance against foreign interference. As we achieve a historic transformation in Venezuela, we are also anticipating significant changes in Cuba"

In another conference he said that- "Cuba is in "deep trouble" on a humanitarian basis and that U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio was dealing with the issue which may or may not be a "friendly takeover."

Tensions between Donald Trump and Cuba have resurfaced in political and strategic discourse, shaped by a mix of security concerns, geopolitical rivalry, and domestic electoral calculations.

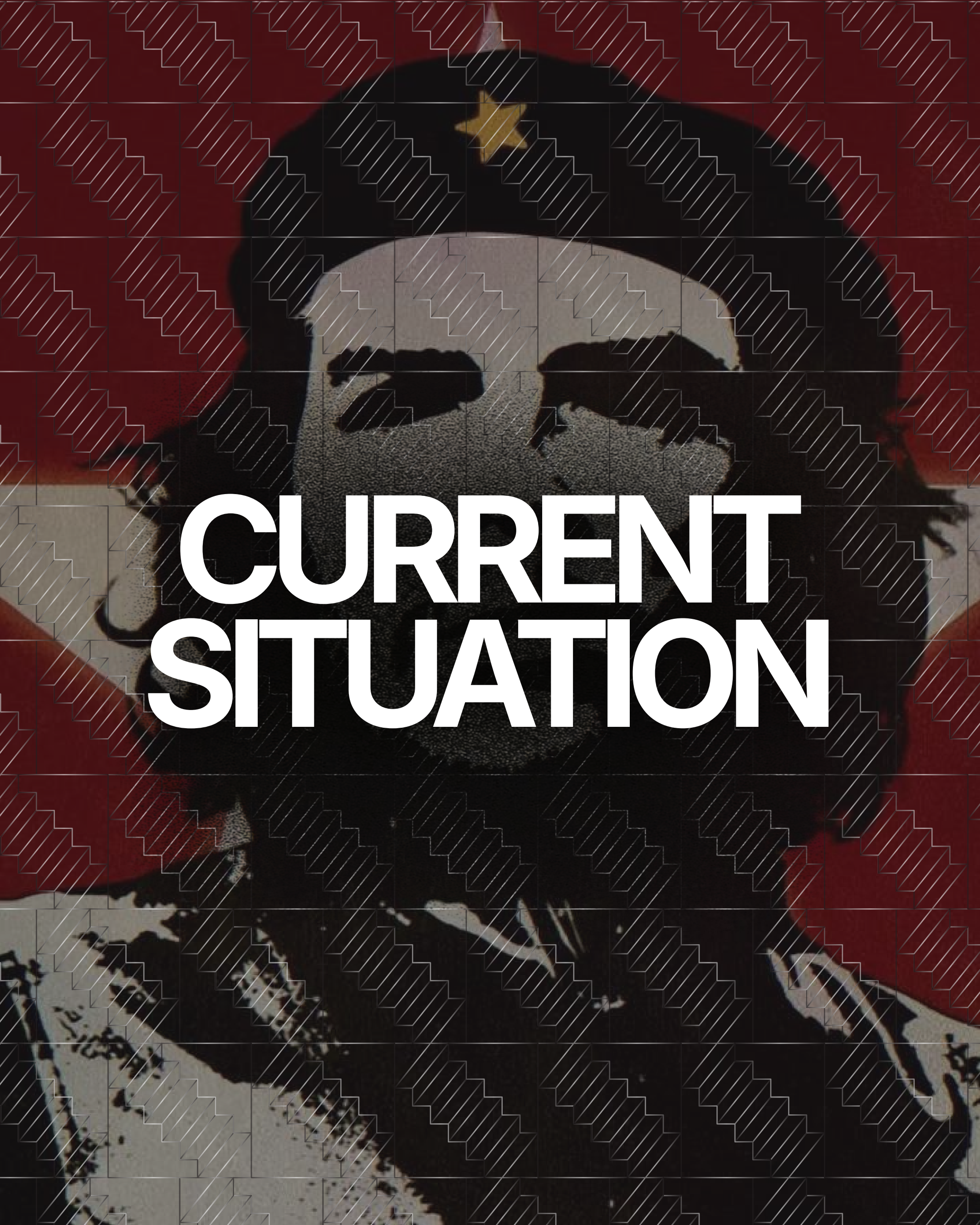
4.GROWING INVOLVEMENT OF CHINA IN CUBA'S DEVELOPMENT:

Over the years, Beijing has expanded its footprint on the island through investments and technical cooperation. However, Washington views this engagement with suspicion. U.S. officials argue that China's presence could extend beyond economic cooperation into the realm of intelligence gathering, potentially enabling surveillance activities close to American territory. Given Cuba's geographical proximity to the United States, such concerns are framed as a direct challenge to national security.

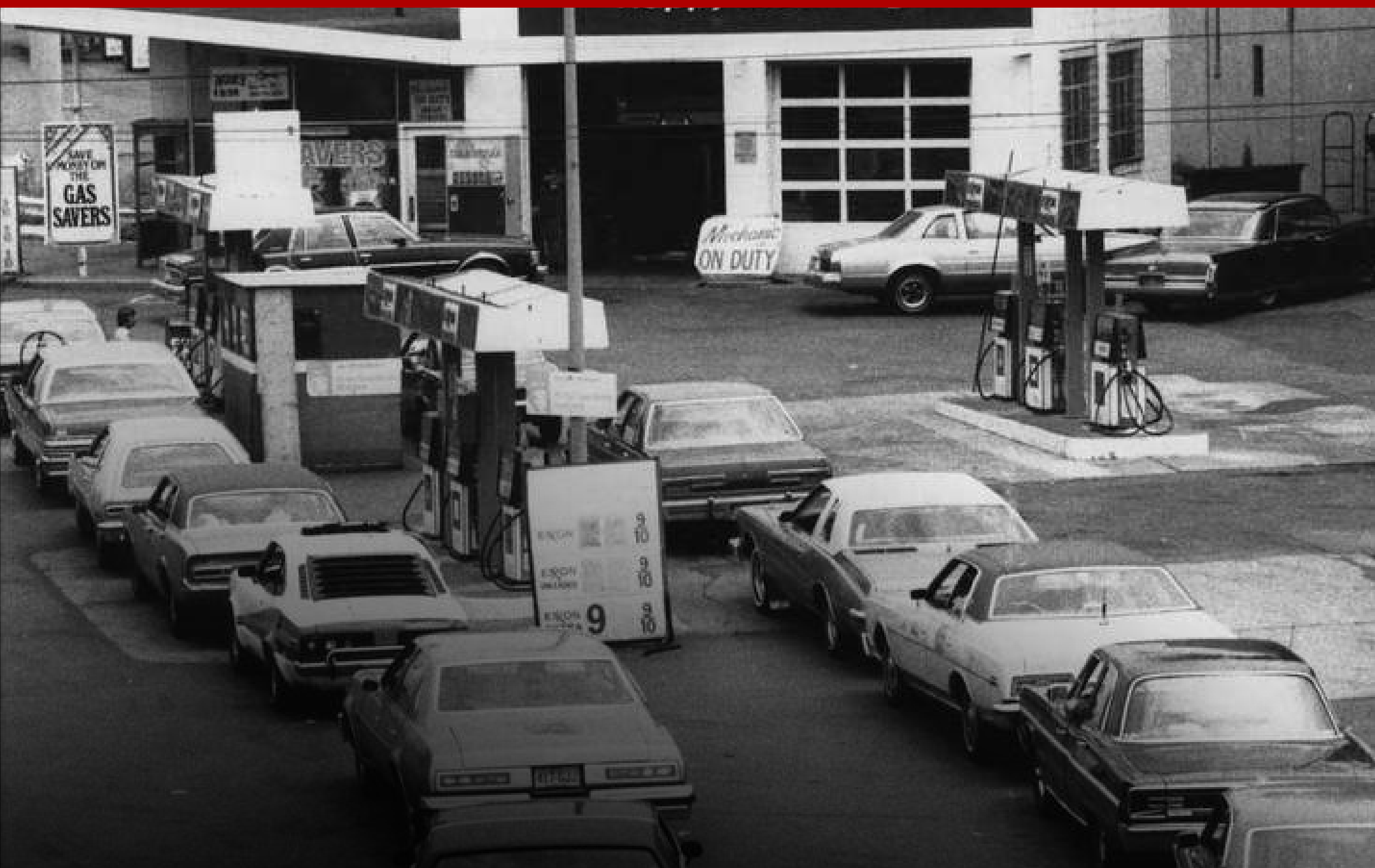
This perception has been reinforced by voices within the U.S. political establishment, including Marco Rubio, a Cuban-American figure whose political stance has consistently emphasized a hardline approach toward Havana. His background reflects a broader sentiment among Cuban-American communities, many of whom maintain deep-seated opposition to the Cuban government.

Domestic politics further complicate the issue. The state of Florida plays a pivotal role in U.S. presidential elections due to its status as a swing state. A significant portion of its electorate consists of Cuban and Latin American exiles, whose voting preferences often hinge on foreign policy positions toward Cuba. For the Republican Party, adopting a tough stance on Havana serves not only as a foreign policy signal but also as a strategic move to consolidate electoral support in this region.

Amid the deepening crisis, Cuban President Díaz-Canel confirmed that Havana is in early-stage talks with the Trump administration to resolve their differences. Trump, with Secretary of State Marco Rubio involved, stated a deal would be "very easily made." As a goodwill gesture following Vatican-mediated talks, Cuba announced the release of 51 prisoners in the coming days.



CURRENT SITUATION

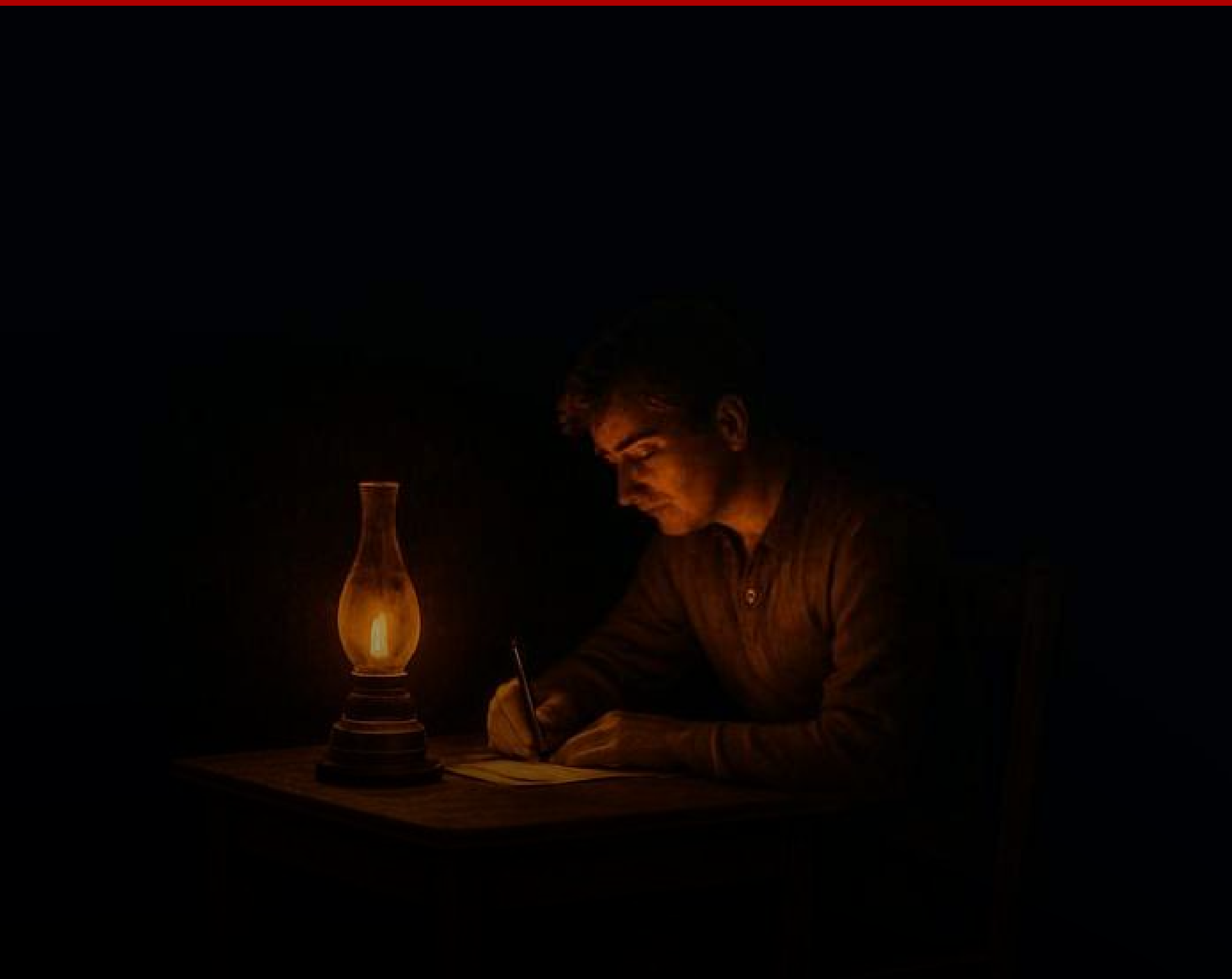


1.OIL CRISIS

Cuba is going through a crisis which will lead to complete collapse of the state if immediate solutions are not taken. Cuba's crisis is oil-centric. The country has not imported a single barrel of oil in February. After the slowing oil imports with Venezuela, Mexico has emerged as the largest exporter of oil to Cuba. But after Trump's threat to impose tariffs on every import to the countries who will export oil to Cuba directly or indirectly, Mexico's leftist president Claudia Sheinbaum Pardo suspended all oil exports to Cuba in February to strengthen its fragile trade negotiations with the USA. After Maduro's arrest and the killing of 32 Cuban soldiers in Operation Absolute Resolve and isolation from South America, Cuba is drowning to collapse at an alarming rate.

2.TOURISM

This oil crisis has a domino effect on other aspects. Cuba is heavily reliant on its tourism. Canada is its biggest tourist market. But amid the fuel crisis, Air Canada has suspended its operations in Cuba, which has affected the Cuban economy to a huge extent. The tourism sector collapsed due to it.



3.ELECTRICITY

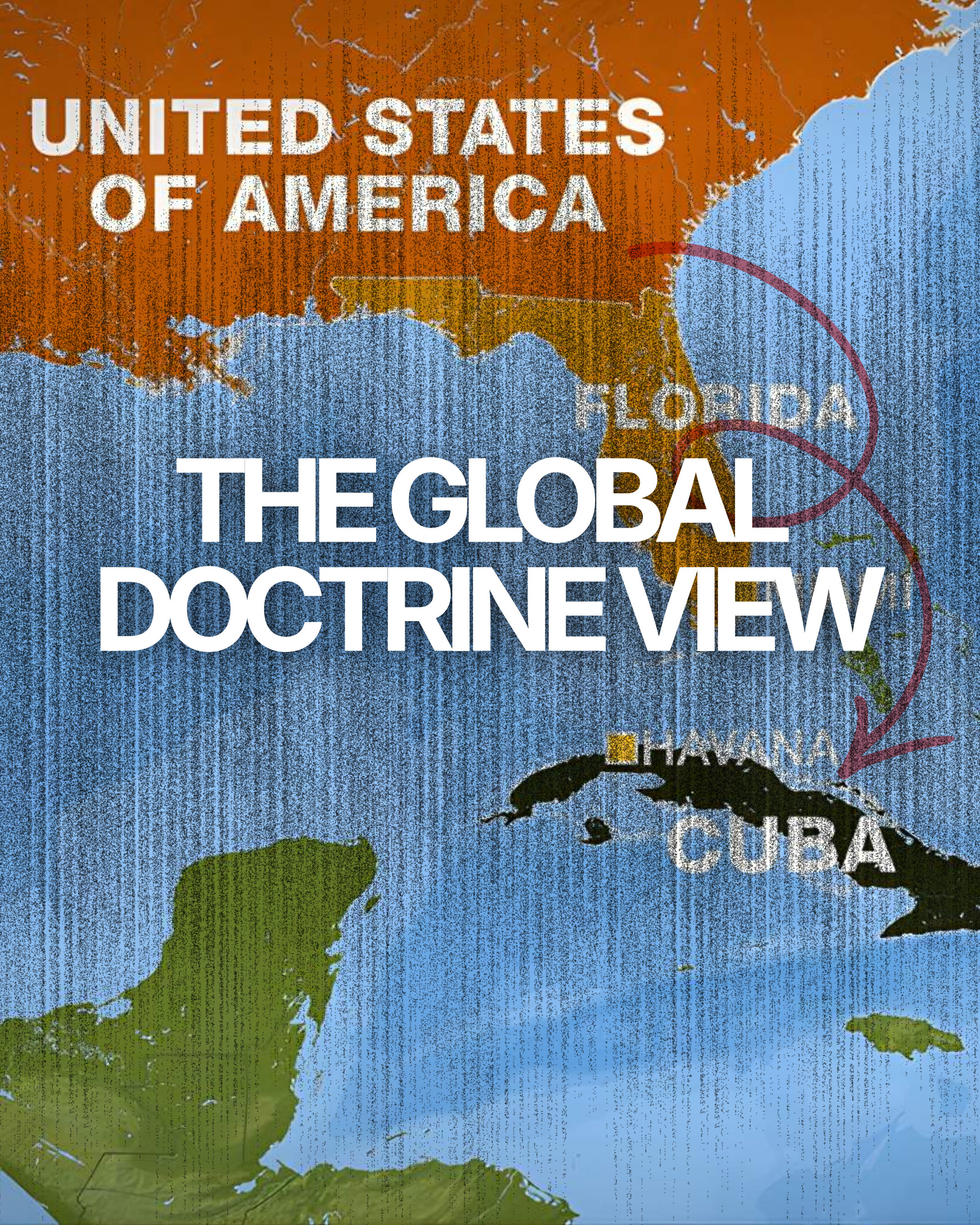
The oil-dependent electricity supply has taken a huge toll. Electricity production has shrunk to half of its demand due to fuel shortage. Load shedding has increased to 20+ hours, which was already at its worst (13-14 hours), and has been predicted to completely go off-grid within weeks.

4.HOSPITALS AND WATER SUPPLY

Due to the fuel and electricity shortage, hospitals have been instructed to halt non-essential surgeries, a clear indication of a failing nation. Hospitals are now even unable to provide chemotherapy and other treatments due to the same issue. Also, many emergency patients far from hospitals are dying as ambulances cannot operate due to fuel shortage. Water supplies are also being disrupted due to heavy dependency on tankers, which run on fuel. The garbage collection process has also collapsed due to the crisis.

5.NON-OIL SOURCES

The USA has also targeted another non-oil source of hard currency for the Cuban regime, the medical brigade program, which sends doctors abroad and generates huge remittances. Trump, on his first day in office, banned Orbit, which severely affected the channel through which US dollars were reaching the island in the form of remittances. The USA has also restricted the financial activity of GAESA, a military conglomerate that serves as the heart of the Cuban economy. Its role is massive, with its revenues representing close to 40% of Cuba's GDP. Furthermore, GAESA's exports account for roughly a third of the island's total, and its revenues are more than three times greater than the entire Cuban state budget. This has crippled the Cuban economy.



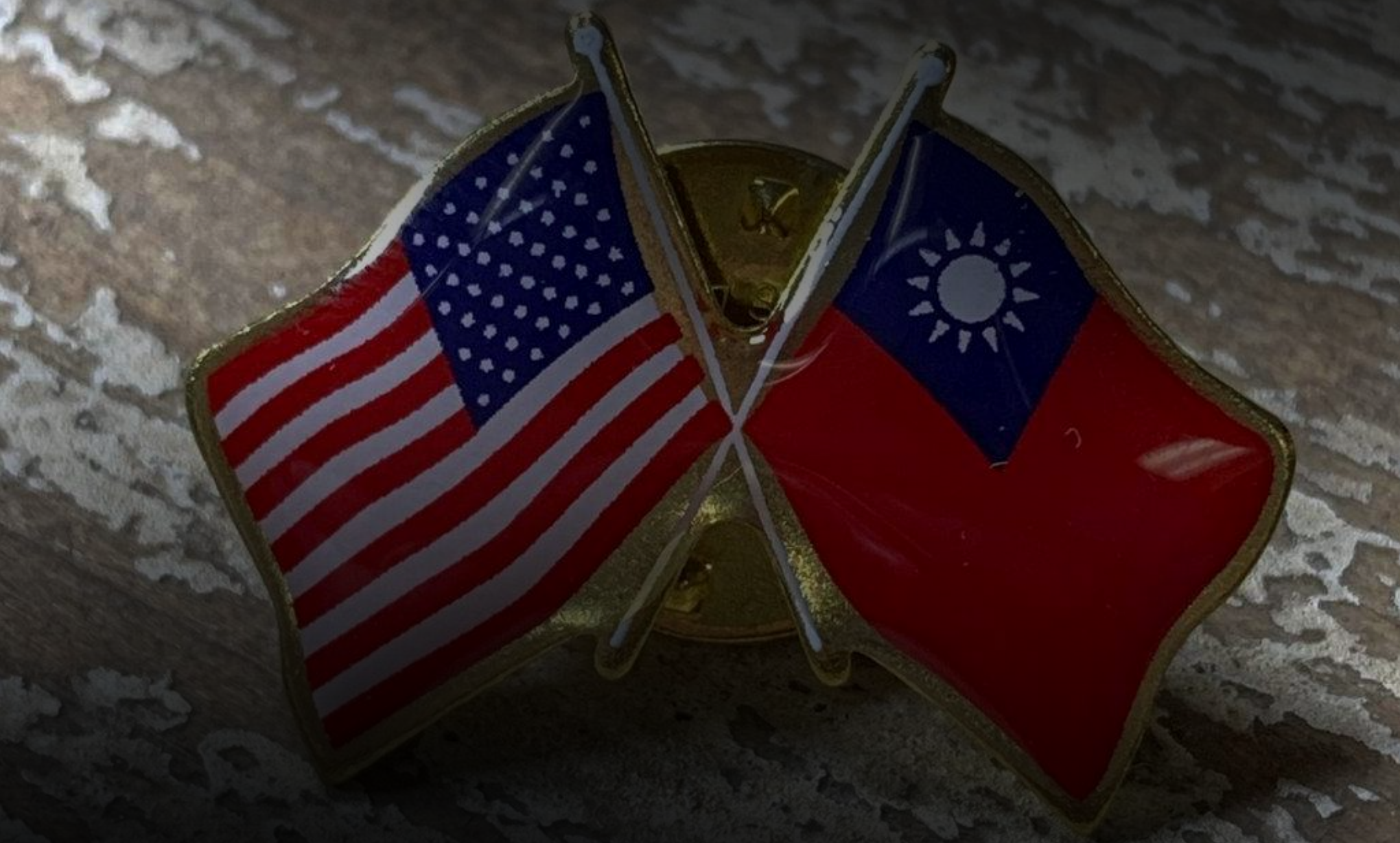
THE GLOBAL DOCTRINE VIEW

BUT WHY DOES TRUMP WANT CUBA SUDDENLY?

This sudden "friendly takeover" is coming up for discussion for many reasons. One reason might be USA's current loose position in the Indo-Pacific region due to the Iran conflict. USA has engaged in Iran and that caused its Indo-Pacific fleet to concentrate towards the Middle East including the USS Abraham Lincoln aircraft carrier as The Pentagon moved the USS Abraham Lincoln carrier strike group from the South China Sea in the Indo-Pacific toward the Middle East as tensions between the US and Iran escalated. This has given China the space to move its navy towards Taiwan.

Located approximately 90 miles south of Florida, Cuba has long been a point of contention for Trump and the U.S. Cuba and the U.S. have had a strained relationship for nearly seven decades, dating back to Cuban leader Fidel Castro's overthrow of the U.S.-backed government in 1959.

In the daily update, Taiwan's defense ministry has said on March 15 that they have identified 26 Chinese military aircraft, concentrated in the Taiwan Strait, over the previous 24 hours. It last reported that many on February 25, when it spotted 30 aircraft after saying Beijing was carrying out another "joint combat readiness patrol"



This sudden development has sent the USA in a strategic dilemma. If they do not respond swiftly, they might lose the Taiwan influence. So it is necessary for the USA to finish the "Operation Epic Fury" so that they can tackle China in the South China Sea region. To move out of Iran without domestic outrage, Cuba might be used as Shield to satisfy the domestic demand of Hegemony and win.

PREDICTIONS

President Díaz-Canel will resign by his own will due to the economic condition of Cuba.

-EDITOR

The Trump administration will intervene and place Raúl Castro's grandson as new president.

-ANALYST

A negotiated settlement is likely to be pursued, as failure to reach an agreement may result in escalating political and economic pressures.

-PUBLISHER

SOURCES:

PICTURES COLLEECTED

Trump raises prospect of 'friendly takeover' of Cuba, says Rubio in talks

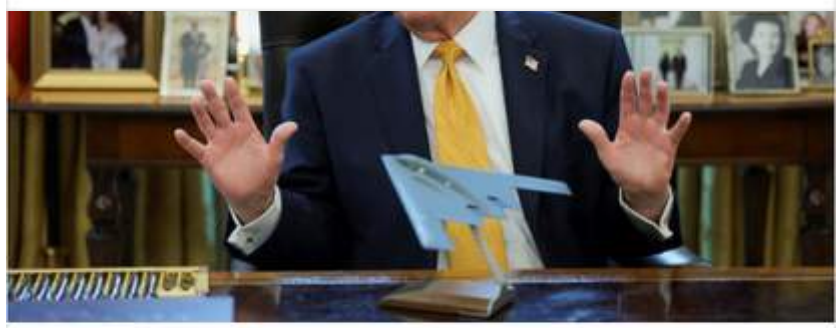
Trump described Cuba as a failing nation in need of change.

Reuters / Mar 1

Cuba opens talks with U.S. as oil blockade takes a toll

Cuba has opened talks with the U.S. government, President Miguel Diaz-Canel said on Friday, as an oil blockade imposed by U.S. President Donald Trump pushes the Communist-run nation deeper into economic crisis.

Reuters / Mar 13



Trump on Cuba: 'They're a very weakened nation right now'

President Trump said he believes he'll have 'the honor of taking Cuba' as the island nation faces economic struggle and power outages.

USA TODAY / Mar 17

Chronology of U.S.-Cuba Relations

1775–83: The thirteen North American colonies rebel against Great Britain and establish the United States, thereby encouraging commerce between the newly independent nation and Cuba.

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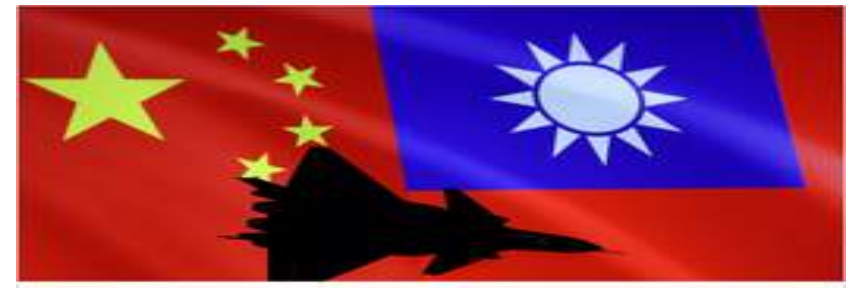

Taiwan says large-scale Chinese military flights return after unusual absence

Taiwan on Sunday reported the return of large-scale Chinese air force activities around the island after an unexplained absence of more than two weeks that prompted speculation in Taipei as to Beijing's motives.

Reuters / Mar 15

What is happening in Cuba? Economic struggles, US tensions explained

Trump has recently increased pressure on the island nation of Cuba, adding March 17 Washington would be doing "something with Cuba" soon.

USA TODAY / Mar 17

Abraham Lincoln Carrier Strike Group Now in U.S. Central Command

The Abraham Lincoln Carrier Strike Group is now in the Middle East, having been redirected from its Indo-Pacific deployment to the region in recent weeks as tensions with Iran increase, USNI News has learned. Aircraft carrier USS Abraha...

USNI News / Jan 26